

Activity 10 — DBS Bank — Scaling Innovation Across 25,000 People

Course Fast-Track Innovations with Agile Design Thinking and Generative AI (GenAI)

WSQ Course Code TGS-2024049781

Topic Topic 04: Scaling and Sustaining Innovations with Agile Design Thinking and Generative AI

Duration 50 minutes · Group size: 3–5 participants

Tools Padlet Classroom Board, ChatGPT or Microsoft Copilot

Learning Outcome Addressed

LO4 · A2 · A6 · K2 · K3 — Develop strategies to proliferate design thinking across the organisation; drivers of organisational growth.

The Real Case

Around 2014 DBS Bank set out to 'Make Banking Joyful' and to become a technology company delivering banking. Rather than launching an innovation lab and hoping it spread, DBS changed the operating system: it ran large-scale hackathons pairing bankers with start-ups, trained thousands of staff in customer journey thinking, moved the majority of its technology in-house from outsourced vendors, and adopted the discipline of measuring customer time saved — reporting tens of millions of customer hours eliminated from waiting and rework. Senior leaders were required to participate, not merely sponsor. DBS was subsequently named the world's best bank by multiple international publications. The instructive part is not the awards but the mechanism: DBS changed what got measured, who had authority, and what leaders personally did — and let the culture follow.

Your Scenario

You have run one successful design thinking pilot in your department. Your director is impressed and asks you to 'roll it out to the whole division' — 400 people — with no additional budget and no change to existing KPIs.

What You Will Do

Learners analyse how a large regulated organisation actually scaled human-centred innovation, and build a realistic scaling plan that changes measurement, authority and leadership behaviour rather than merely running more training.

What you will produce

A one-page scaling plan for the learner's own organisation covering the first 90 days, the metric that would change, and the leadership behaviour required.

Step-by-Step Instructions

1. Rejoin the Padlet classroom board, Activity 10 section.
2. Read the DBS case in the Learner Guide (Activity 10) with your group.
3. Post the three mechanisms DBS used that were NOT training.
4. For your own organisation, post one metric you would change and what behaviour that change would trigger.
5. Ask ChatGPT: 'What are the most common failure modes when scaling design thinking in a large regulated organisation?' Evaluate its list against the DBS case.
6. Draft your 90-day scaling plan: scope, metric, leadership behaviour, first team.
7. Post it and comment on another group's plan, naming the assumption most likely to break.

Discussion Questions

1. DBS measured 'customer hours saved'. Why is that a more powerful scaling lever than counting how many staff attended training?
2. Your director offers no budget and no KPI change. What is the honest risk to the rollout, and how do you surface it professionally?
3. DBS required leaders to participate rather than sponsor. What is the practical difference, and which does your organisation do?
4. Which is harder to scale — the method, the mindset, or the authority to act on what you learn? Defend your ranking.
5. Where would GenAI genuinely accelerate a 400-person rollout, and where would it create the illusion of progress?

How You Know You Are Done

Your plan changes at least one measurement and one authority, not just the training calendar, and its scope is small enough to be real.

Debrief — What the Room Should Conclude

Training 400 people produces 400 people who know the vocabulary and cannot use it, unless three other things change: what gets measured, who is allowed to decide, and what senior leaders visibly do. DBS's customer-hours-saved metric is instructive because it is a customer-value measure that the whole organisation could act on, unlike a training-completion count, which measures activity and changes nothing. The honest answer to the no-budget no-KPI-change instruction is that the rollout will produce awareness without behaviour — and the professional way to say so is to propose a smaller scope with a real metric attached rather than to accept an unachievable one. GenAI can genuinely help with scale here: producing training material, synthesising feedback

from 400 people, spotting where teams are stuck. It cannot manufacture the authority that makes the method usable.